

PAUL WILDE EDIT

While in London, I travel to Bermondsey in South London and caught up with a real actor, Paul Wilde, who happens to be disabled but uses his condition to further his acting career to great effect. Travel Radio Australia, and we're in South London at the moment in a place called Bermondsey, which is very traditional South London. And I have one of the locals here who is esteemed UK actor, Paul Wilde, and he is a real local of Bermondsey.

And Paul, welcome to the programme. Great to see you. Now, Paul, you're very well connected with the area around here and the history is incredible.

It's South London. You've been involved in the area for quite some time. Tell us a bit about your background.

Yeah, well, I moved up here from Southampton to London to follow my dream of being an actor. And I landed here in Bermondsey, and I love it. I'll be moving soon, but I love it here.

The people are so real, you know, and so easy to get on with. And it's such a cool place to live. It's been described as a village, really, isn't it, in the middle of London? Well, everywhere was originally a village that has just grown.

I mean, London itself started off as a little hamlet by the river. And they just grow into each other like Peckham was a village, Bermondsey. And now they kind of meet on the old Kent Road.

So a lot of that mentality stays the same. You know, people are, I'm Bermondsey boy, or I'm Peckhamite. You know, and they're close, and they're real, and it is good.

So to see that in a city like London, that sort of thing still exists. Now, you're an actor, professional actor, and you have a disability as well. You lost your leg a little while ago.

And tell us about that. And I've got to know you pretty well over the last week or so. And I think it gives you a fantastic uniqueness as an actor.

And that certainly sometimes has helped you along the way, hasn't it? Yes, I'm still waiting for my James Bond baddie audition. I haven't got that yet, perhaps because I haven't got a cat. But it does, because I have a prosthetic I can use.

So I can take roles that are walking or in a wheelchair or showing a prosthetic. So it does give me a wider range than when I was just acting normally with just two legs. So yeah, it's kind of in a funny way helped my career.

Tell us about this movie you've recently started. Is it the dance movie? Tell us a bit about that. Yeah, it's a movie called The Broken Arrow.

We just had a premiere of it, which has been very well received. So it's about the game of dance, which is very popular here in England. So the premise is a famous dance player on the rise through his career.

But he's a bit of a nasty fellow. And as he gets drunk, wins a cup, falls asleep with a cup that is out on a freezing night, ends up having his arm amputated. It's not his flowing arm.

And he's all depressed and trying to earn money, conning people, going up to pubs like that. No, you want to go with darts? I'm an ex-arm force. He's lost my arm in the forces.

Oh, yeah, give me a game. So he's conning people out of money. And then they hear about the Olympic Games having darts involved.

There's a scene where they say, darts? So it's a game. It's the Olympic Games. They said, OK, well, then we'll include it then.

It'll go away after that, just like synchronized swimming. So he tries out for the Paralympic darts team and has to be his nemesis, who is the best Paralympic darts player or Paralympian in that particular sport. And so he goes about trying to beat him.

And I play his nemesis. So I have a wheelchair and it's done like a spaceship. And I have an oxygen tank and a breathing mask.

And my name is Darts Vader in the film. And it's hilarious. And it's a good old British comedy like they used to make.

Yeah, absolutely brilliant. Now, you were telling me recently you took a world trip to America. And tell us a bit about that and some of your experiences.

Well, I was doing a play last year and it was touring the country. And I was going from London up to Wales, up to Manchester, to Malcolm and all over the place. And it just dawned on me.

I thought, well, if I can do this in my wheelchair, why can't I go anywhere in my wheelchair? And so I thought I always wanted to travel across the States. And so I got together with a travel agent who organized all my stuff. And I literally went from London Waterloo down to Southampton, where I come from.

And it was nice to leave my own town on a Queen Mary. And so as we leave the docks, looking at all the old places, you get a lovely view. And off I went to New York.

I'm from New York. I went up to Canada, where I visited Niagara Falls and went out in the little boat. And then I came back to New York.

Then I went to Chicago, where I met my travel agent. She lives there. I stayed in Chicago for a

few days.

It's my favorite town. It's a brilliant place. And then I went out on the Amtrak, all the way in my own little sleeper, all the way across to San Francisco, through the Colorados and everything.

And it was so beautiful. And there I went to Alcatraz in San Francisco, and I flew back. And if anybody's really interested, you can go to my YouTube channel, Paul Wilde, and you can follow my journey.

I blocked it in various stages, and you can watch how I coped with different difficulties and different issues that arise for people in my situation. Nothing is, you know, insurmountable. If someone with one leg can do the whole world, what's holding everyone back? I mean, it's real life, isn't it? It's great.

And I'm sure that you had some unusual and funny experiences along the way. Do you have any anecdotes that you could let us know about? Well, unusual, sad, and funny. The train I got from New York to Canada was fairly busy.

And I see a disabled seat with a wheelchair, I think, because it wasn't a sleeper, because it was a one-day short through New York State. Whereas Amtrak, I had my own sleeper and toilet and everything. Here I was just with a normal disabled toilet in the carriage, and nobody used the normal toilet.

They all used a disabled toilet. And they start, and of course the sink starts getting blocked out with toilet paper, and the toilet does, and the floor does, and it becomes unusable. And I've put this on my blog because I thought I was getting quite indignant.

How can these people? And then I took a picture of it, and then I took a picture of the normal toilet, and I had a tiny little piece of paper on the floor you could barely see. And I thought, this is crazy. So I made my concerns known to the train company.

And on the way back, the journey back, I had this guard sitting next to me, guarding the disabled toilet for me. And he was fantastic, because he'd done the journey so often, he knew everything about every step of the Hudson River that you follow, all the history, the different stops, you know, the buildings, the derelict buildings, what they were. And so I got this amazing travel guide with me, who was also guarding the disabled toilet for me.

So the journey back was fine, but the journey there was frantic, going to Niagara, yes. That's funny. Little things like that occur, you know, that you forget about.

But I did put this in my blog and a few little things like that, you know, a few issues that I have. But I didn't have too many issues, generally, pretty good. And a couple of highlights.

Highlights being, whatever train station we pulled into, Amtrak, they have these red caps, they

wear red berries, so you can see them, and they're there to help you. And they take every bit of strain off of you because they're so good, you know. My major sightseeing highlight had to be Alcatraz, because it's always a place I've wanted to visit.

And you go over there and you actually see how small it is. It's mind-blowing. It really is a small place.

The cells are small. The canteens are small. The reception area is small.

Everything is so tight and compact. And you visit the cells of real ex-criminals, you know, and the story. And you can really get a good vibe from the place of how, what it must have been like.

Because, yes, a very claustrophobic place, but a joy to visit. And, of course, going back to and from the island is a fantastic trip. And I met this guy in a bar in San Francisco, and he'd actually swam from Alcatraz to San Francisco, which is dangerous to do, but he does it.

And there's sharks and everything, you know. Absolutely, tides, cold water, and he does it. And I said to him, so how long does it take you to swim to Alcatraz? He said, Paul, nobody swims to Alcatraz.

You only swim away from it. If you're lucky, if you don't get dashed on the rocks or whatever. It can be done because people have found out how to do it these days and where the tides go.

And so it's swimmable now. And it was nice to meet someone who actually swam there. So that was a highlight in San Francisco.

Yeah, it was good. The whole thing was real buzz, just doing what I was doing and, you know. And like I say, what's stopping everybody else? Well, it's not your disability physically, it's your disability mentally, because that's what holds anybody back from doing and trying anything.

So, yeah, it was good. And as I said, if you want to follow the travel blog, it's on my YouTube channel, Paul Wild. Brilliant.

Paul, thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia. Fascinating stories. And, yeah, we'll be following you and your blogs and your movie journeys in the future.

And we'll catch up with you again for some more insights about London and everything in the entertainment world of the UK. Please do, please do. And pleasure to meet you, Geoff.

Thank you. Paul Wild, check him out on YouTube. And he has various other links.

Paul Wild Actor, that's W-I-L-D. And fascinating stuff.